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19. Freshman Pro-Tips

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This [Reddit post](#) discusses some tips for incoming freshmen. I'll highlight some of the pro-tips right here and add some of my own:

- Wear your lanyard throughout the first two weeks. You will look back to that moment and smile.
- Go to class. Repeat after me: go to class. If you're not a morning person, avoid registering for 8:30am classes.
- Study for the midterms! They'll come sooner than you think.
- Twitter is especially helpful for keeping up with Kenyan news.
- Seek help. Colleges have a sharing/counselling platform. Reach out. Your mental health is really important.
- For some reason, Americans are obsessed with Snapchat. Don't delete WhatsApp; that's how you'll keep in touch with your Kenyan friends. Facebook is all over the place.
- Don't sign up for unnecessary listservs. You don't want to be receiving 147 emails per hour. But if it's a free-food listserv, SUBSCRIBE. Text your buddies when there's a free giveaway; they'll return the favor.
- Library jobs are the best. However, they get filled up super-fast. Apply early.
- When shopping, don't mentally convert the dollars into Kenyan shillings. Yes, a 500ml Fanta costs \$1.50.
- There's a readily available daily dose of ice-cream, chicken burgers and pizza. Go to the gym once a week.
- Sleep more than you study, study more than you party, and party as much as you can. In short, manage your time. And no, sleep is not for the weak!
- Use Google Calendar. It is super clutch in keeping track of appointments and events.
- Buy/ Rent textbooks from Amazon Prime. College bookstores are expensive. Don't torrent PDFs! Torrenting will get you into trouble.

- Maintain your diligent work ethic. Don't be that guy who peaked in high school.
- Going to your professor's office hours is not a sign of weakness.
- Read the course syllabus. Note down when you have exams, lest you be surprised one morning.
- Go to most of the frosh-themed events since most people will be trying to know each other. It's an easy way to make acquaintances/ friends. Joining a campus group is another way to make friends.
- Only date people above 18 and are in college (no high school kids!). In the same vein, avoid dating the person next door or in your class of 20 people.
- Do your papers, problem sets and take-homes before they are due. It will save you from stressful last-minute panic.
- Apparently, Americans have free refills, i.e. you buy a drink once, and you can refill your cup for free/ a marginal cost. Exploit this opportunity whenever possible.
- Avoid debt. Although you need a credit card to raise your credit score (will come in handy when you're trying to buy a house/car), use the credit card only for purchases that you can pay off at the end of the month. The interest rates are quite steep!
- In between classes, rest at the library. Going back to your dorm for a quick nap makes it less likely for you to attend your next class.
- Go to parties; don't host them. There are clean-ups, stolen stuff, broken things and too much drama. Also, be a good guest when invited.
- Reach out of your group, especially if +2 Kenyans are admitted. It's nice to have someone you can speak to in Kiswahili, but don't cling to each other such that you have no time for other people.
- Skim the assigned readings before class.

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